AREC 570 Data Checklist

Unit 5 · Data

Lauren Chenarides

Use this checklist as you are preparing to write your data section. The rows follow the data-section components in Lecture 5.5; the empirical strategy checklist in Unit 6 picks up where this one ends. Sources: **GS** = Gentzkow and Shapiro, *Code and Data for the Social Sciences* (Lectures 5.3 and 5.4); **AJAE** = AJAE Author Guidelines and Author's Final Checklist.

#	Relevant section	Purpose
1	Fit to the hypotheses	**Data requirements.** For one hypothesis from your conceptual framework: the outcome, the explanatory factor, the comparison that generates variation, the population, and the conditions needed for interpretation.
2	Source and sample	**Source and provenance [AJAE].** Who collected the data, why, when and where, and how observations were recorded.
3	Source and sample	**Coverage and access.** The population the source covers, and any access, licensing, or confidentiality conditions.
4	Source and sample	**Sample selection.** Every inclusion and exclusion rule, the order in which the rules are applied, and the observations lost at each step.
5	Source and sample	**Comparison with the population.** How the analytic sample compares with the population of interest, and whether attrition or missingness differs across groups or time.
6	Unit and measures	**Observation unit and key [GS].** What one row represents (for example, a county in a year), and the fields that uniquely identify each row (for example, county code and year).
7	Unit and measures	**Variable construction.** For each central variable: the concept from the framework, the source fields, the unit and reference period, the transformation, and how to read the resulting value.
8	Unit and measures	**Missing data and imputation.** Which fields are missing, how many observations are affected, where the loss is concentrated, and, if imputed, the method and an indicator for imputed values.
9	Unit and measures	**Proxies and scope.** For each proxy: the concept it stands in for, why it represents that concept, what it omits, and the limit this places on your claims.
10	Evidence and repository	**Descriptive evidence.** The scale and composition of the sample, the variation the hypotheses require, and differences across periods or comparison groups.
11	Evidence and repository	**Repository [GS, AJAE].** The README, the scripts that construct each reported value, and which files are shared or restricted.